

How to Bake a Cake – Beginner's Guide

Lesson 8: Decorating Basics

Decorating Basics - Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. ****Leveling Layers**** – Creating even, uniform cake tiers before frosting.
2. ****Spreading Frosting**** – Techniques for a smooth, even coating (crumb coat vs. final coat).
3. ****Adding Sprinkles**** – Placement, timing, and types of sprinkles for visual impact.
4. ****Crumb Coat Demonstration**** – The purpose and step by step method for a clean, crumb free finish.

Summary

Decorating a cake starts with a solid foundation: each baked layer must be level so the finished cake stands straight and looks professional. After trimming and stacking the layers, a thin “crumb coat” of frosting is applied. This initial coat captures loose crumbs, preventing them from mixing into the final layer of frosting and giving a sleek canvas for decoration.

Once the crumb coat is set (usually 10–15 /minutes in the refrigerator), a second, thicker coat of frosting is spread smoothly using an offset spatula or bench scraper. The final surface should be free of streaks and air bubbles. Sprinkles are added after the final coat has softened slightly—just enough to adhere but not melt—allowing you to create borders, patterns, or a full coverage “confetti” effect. Mastering these basic steps builds confidence for more advanced piping, fondant, and sculpted designs.

Important Points

- ****Leveling****
 - Use a serrated cake leveler or a long serrated knife.
 - Trim each layer to the same height (usually 1 1.5 /in).
 - Rotate the cake plate while cutting to keep the cut straight.
- ****Crumb Coat****
 - Apply a thin layer (“H¼ cup frosting for a 9 in round).
 - Use a bench scraper to smooth the sides; a turntable helps.
 - Chill 10–15 /min to firm the coat before the final frosting.
- ****Final Frosting****
 - Start with a generous “dome” on top, then spread down the sides.
 - Work quickly to avoid the frosting warming and becoming runny.
 - For a mirror finish, keep the frosting slightly warm (“H70 /°F).
- ****Sprinkles****
 - Add when frosting is soft but not liquid (“H5–10 /min after final coat).
 - For borders, use a small offset spatula to press sprinkles onto the edge.

- Larger non edible decorations (candy, edible glitter) should be placed after the cake is fully set.
 - **Tools**
- Offset spatula, bench scraper, turntable, serrated leveler, piping bag (optional for crumb coat).

Examples

Example 1 – Simple Two Layer Vanilla Cake

1. **Level** each baked layer to 1 /in thick.
2. **Stack** with a thin layer of buttercream between layers.
3. **Crumb coat**: Spread ¼ cup buttercream all around, smooth with a bench scraper, chill 12 /min.
4. **Final coat**: Apply 1 ½ cups buttercream, smooth, and chill 5 /min.
5. **Sprinkles**: Press rainbow non pareve sprinkles onto the sides for a festive border.

Result: A clean, even cake with a colorful, eye catching edge—perfect for birthdays.

Example 2 – Chocolate Sheet Cake with Confetti Sprinkles

1. **Level** the sheet cake using a long serrated knife.
2. **Crumb coat**: Lightly spread ½ cup chocolate ganache, smooth, refrigerate 10 /min.
3. **Final coat**: Apply 2 cups ganache, smooth with an offset spatula.
4. **Sprinkles**: While the ganache is still glossy, sprinkle a generous amount of chocolate flavored confetti over the entire surface.

Result: A glossy, crumb free chocolate cake with a fun, uniform confetti finish.

Quick Review

1. Why is it important to level cake layers before frosting?
2. What is the purpose of a crumb coat, and how long should it chill?
3. Which tool helps you achieve a perfectly smooth side surface?
4. When should you add sprinkles for the best adhesion?
5. Name two types of sprinkles and a situation where each works best.

Further Reading

- **Piping Basics:** Learn basic piping tips to add rosettes, borders, and writing.
- **Fondant Fundamentals:** Turning a smooth frosting base into a fondant ready canvas.
- **Flavor Pairings:** Matching frostings and fillings for balanced taste.
- **Advanced Textures:** Using mousse, ganache, and whipped buttercream for varied mouthfeel.

Happy decorating! Ø<ß,'(

